

Ninebark

Physocarpus opulifolius

Eastern Ninebark



QUALITIES

An arching deciduous shrub of stream-banks and rocky openings, growing 5 to 8 feet tall and as wide. The common name comes from its habit of peeling bark in long curling strips, exposing layer after layer of red-brown to cinnamon-colored inner bark — a landmark in the winter garden. Three-lobed maple-like leaves and clusters of small white flowers in late June give way to reddish papery seed capsules that persist into fall.

CARE

Tough as nails. Full sun to part shade; tolerates clay, sand, drought, occasional flooding, urban pollution, road salt, and rabbits. Hardy to USDA Zone 2. Plant 1-gallon or 3-gallon container stock; spaces about 5 ft apart for a loose hedge. Prune in late winter — cut a third of oldest stems to ground each year to keep the shrub vigorous and the bark display visible. Avoid 'Summer Wine' and similar purple-foliage cultivars in stucco-architecture settings — the foliage clashes.

HISTORY

Ninebark's name appears across Indigenous, Colonial, and modern horticulture. The Cherokee used a bark decoction as an emetic and for women's medicine; the Ojibwe used it in post-childbirth care. Settlers in eastern North America named it "ninebark" for the apparent nine layers of shedding bark. It became a foundational shrub in 20th-century American landscape design before the cultivar explosion of the 2000s; the straight species is now experiencing a quiet revival among ecological designers.

REASON TO BE

Ninebark anchors residential bed design with a visual presence that shifts every month: white pollinator-loaded flowers in June, reddish seedheads through summer, golden leaves in October, and the celebrated peeling bark from November through April. Native bees, hover flies, and small butterflies work the bloom. Birds nest in the dense branching. It is one of the few native shrubs that holds its own visually against architectural elements — stucco, stone, brick — without disappearing into the green.